

Radical Transformation Plan — August to December

Profile: Male, 23 yrs (DOB Oct), 175 cm, 59 kg → target 65–68 kg **Training history:** Former regular lifter, 6–8 month layoff, some muscle loss + mild fat gain **Diet:** Lacto-vegetarian, primarily Indian, open to other cuisines **Supplements available:** Whey (ON), creatine (willing to start) **Goal:** Lean bulk — maximize muscle, minimize fat gain **Training access:** Full commercial gym, 5 days/week (flexible)

1. The Honest Starting Point

A few things worth knowing before you start, because they change how you should judge "progress":

- **You are not a true beginner.** You trained before and lost muscle mass, not just "never had it." This means you get to benefit from **muscle memory** — previously trained muscle fibers regain size faster than a first-timer builds it. Expect a faster, more visible first 6–10 weeks than a true novice would get.
 - **Realistic gain rate:** 6–9 kg in 5 months (your 59→65–68 target) is aggressive if all of it needs to be lean tissue. A more evidence-based expectation is **0.25–0.4 kg/week** of bodyweight gain once you're past the initial "muscle memory" phase — so realistically **4–6 kg by December**, with the rest coming into 2026 if you keep going. This is not a limitation of effort, it's basic physiology (muscle protein synthesis has a ceiling). Chasing the full 6–9 kg by December will mean a chunk of it is fat.
 - We will bias toward **lean gains** and recalibrate every 4 weeks based on actual data (weight + waist + photos), not guesses.
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2. Calorie & Macro Targets

Using the Mifflin-St Jeor equation (most accurate widely-validated formula):

$$\begin{aligned} \text{BMR} &= 10 \times \text{weight}(\text{kg}) + 6.25 \times \text{height}(\text{cm}) - 5 \times \text{age} + 5 \\ \text{BMR} &= 10(59) + 6.25(175) - 5(23) + 5 \approx 1574 \text{ kcal} \end{aligned}$$

Activity multiplier for training 5x/week + normal daily activity (~1.55):

$$\text{TDEE (maintenance)} \approx 1574 \times 1.55 \approx 2440 \text{ kcal/day}$$

Lean bulk surplus: +300 to +350 kcal/day

Starting Targets (Week 1)

	Amount	Calories
Total calories	~2,750–2,800 kcal	
Protein	150 g	600 kcal
Fat	75–80 g	700 kcal
Carbohydrates	~370–380 g	1,450–1,500 kcal

Why these numbers:

- **Protein at ~2.5 g/kg current bodyweight** — vegetarian sources have slightly lower leucine content and digestibility (PDCAAS/DIAAS) than animal protein, so vegetarians benefit from the higher end of the 1.6–2.2 g/kg range typically cited in muscle-building research (Morton et al., 2018 meta-analysis puts the plateau around 1.6 g/kg, but vegetarian-specific guidance and practical bodybuilding literature push this to 2–2.4 g/kg to compensate).
- **Fat at ~25% of calories** — enough to support testosterone production, not so much it crowds out carbs for training performance.
- **Carbs get the rest** — you need this for gym performance, glycogen replenishment, and they're the primary lean-bulk lever.

Recalibration Rule (important)

- Weigh yourself **every morning**, same conditions, track the **weekly average** (not daily fluctuation).
- If weekly-average weight gain is **less than 0.2 kg/week** for 2 straight weeks → add 150 kcal (mostly carbs).
- If gaining **more than 0.5 kg/week** → cut 150–200 kcal, you're gaining fat too fast.
- Reassess protein target as bodyweight climbs (recalculate at 62 kg and 65 kg checkpoints).

3. Diet Plan — Lacto-Vegetarian Indian-Primary

Your Key Protein Sources (rank by protein density + quality)

Food	Protein (per 100g/serving)
Whey protein (ON)	~24g per scoop
Paneer	~18g/100g
Soy chunks (nutrela)	~52g/100g dry (huge — cheap staple)
Tofu	~8g/100g
Greek yogurt / hung curd	~10g/100g
Moong dal / masoor dal	~24g/100g dry
Chana (chickpeas)/rajma	~19g/100g dry
Milk (full fat)	~3.4g/100ml
Peanuts/peanut butter	~25g/100g
Quinoa	~14g/100g dry
Sprouts	~7g/100g
Eggs — not applicable (lacto-veg)	—

Soy chunks and paneer are going to be your workhorses — cheap, high protein, easy to cook Indian-style, and versatile.

Sample Day 1 (Training Day) — ~2,800 kcal / 150g protein

Meal 1 — Pre-breakfast (on waking)

- 1 scoop whey in water or milk

Meal 2 — Breakfast

- 3 whole eggs — *skip, veg* → Replace: 200g paneer bhurji (cooked in 1 tsp oil) + 2 multigrain rotis
- 1 glass milk (250ml)

Meal 3 — Mid-morning

- 1 bowl sprouts chaat (100g sprouts) + handful peanuts
- 1 fruit (banana/apple)

Meal 4 — Lunch

- 1.5 cups cooked rice or 3 rotis
- 1 bowl rajma/chana/moong dal (150g cooked)
- 1 bowl paneer or soy chunk sabzi (100g)
- Salad + curd (100g)

Meal 5 — Pre-workout (60-90 min before)

- 1 banana + black coffee (optional, performance boost)

Meal 6 — Post-workout

- 1 scoop whey + 1 scoop carbs source (banana/dates, ~30g sugar equivalent) in water

Meal 7 — Dinner

- 2-3 rotis or 1 cup rice
- Tofu/paneer/soy curry (100-150g)
- Dal (100g)
- Vegetables

Meal 8 — Before bed

- 1 glass milk with a small handful of nuts (almonds/walnuts)

Sample Day 2 (Rest Day) — same calories, slightly lower carbs, same protein

Same structure, drop the pre/post-workout carb-heavy shakes, replace with a normal meal or fruit. Keep protein constant — you build muscle on rest days too.

Grocery List (weekly staples to keep stocked)

- Paneer, tofu, soy chunks, milk, curd/Greek yogurt
 - Moong/masoor/chana dal, rajma, chickpeas
 - Rice, whole wheat atta, oats, quinoa (optional)
 - Peanuts, almonds, walnuts, peanut butter
 - Bananas, apples, seasonal fruit
 - Green vegetables, sprouts
 - Ghee/olive oil (for healthy fats, cook in moderation)
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4. Supplement Protocol

Supplement	Dose	Timing	Why
Whey protein (ON)	1-2 scoops/day	Post-workout + anytime to hit protein target	Convenient protein, fills gaps
Creatine monohydrate	5g/day, every day (no loading needed)	Any time, consistency matters more than timing	Most researched supplement in sports science; increases strength, power output, and muscle water content → measurable strength and size gains over 8-12 weeks (Kreider et al., 2017 ISSN position stand)
Vitamin B12	500-1000 mcg, few times/week	With food	Vegetarians are commonly deficient — B12 only comes reliably from animal sources; supplementing is standard practice
Vitamin D3	1000-2000 IU/day (adjust based on blood test)	With a meal containing fat	Common deficiency in India due to indoor lifestyles; affects testosterone and recovery
Omega-3 (algae-based)	Optional	With food	Vegetarian source of EPA/DHA, supports recovery and joint health

Skip: pre-workouts (unnecessary, just eat a banana + coffee), BCAAs (redundant if protein target is met), fat burners (not needed for a bulk).

5. Training Program — 5-Day Push/Pull/Legs (PPL) Split

Rationale: PPL run twice through the week (with a rest day placed flexibly) hits each muscle group **2x/week**, which research (Schoenfeld et al., 2016) shows is generally superior to 1x/week for hypertrophy, while still allowing recovery. This is the most efficient structure for someone rebuilding lost muscle with 5 solid training days.

Weekly Layout

Day	Focus
Mon	Push (Chest, Shoulders, Triceps)
Tue	Pull (Back, Biceps)
Wed	Legs (Quads, Hams, Glutes, Calves)
Thu	Rest or light cardio/walk
Fri	Push (variation)
Sat	Pull (variation)
Sun	Legs (variation) or full rest if 5 days only

(If you only train 5 days, do Push/Pull/Legs/Rest/Push/Pull/Rest — Legs gets trained once that week, alternate which day gets dropped week to week.)

Core Principles Being Applied

1. **Progressive overload** — add weight or reps every week where possible. This is the #1 driver of muscle growth.
2. **Compound lifts first** — squat/press/pull patterns before isolation, when you're strongest and CNS is fresh.
3. **8-15 rep range primary** — best evidence-backed hypertrophy zone, with some lower-rep (4-6) strength work on main lifts.
4. **RPE 7-9** — leave 1-3 reps in reserve on most sets, true failure only on last set of an exercise.

PUSH DAY A (Mon)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Barbell Bench Press	4 x 6-8	2-3 min
Incline Dumbbell Press	3 x 8-10	90 sec
Seated Dumbbell Shoulder Press	3 x 8-10	90 sec
Cable Lateral Raise	3 x 12-15	60 sec
Triceps Rope Pushdown	3 x 10-12	60 sec
Overhead Triceps Extension	2 x 12-15	60 sec

PULL DAY A (Tue)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Deadlift (conventional)	3 x 5	3 min
Pull-ups / Lat Pulldown	4 x 8-10	2 min
Barbell/Dumbbell Row	3 x 8-10	90 sec
Face Pull	3 x 15	60 sec
Barbell/EZ Bar Curl	3 x 10-12	60 sec
Hammer Curl	2 x 12	60 sec

LEG DAY A (Wed)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Barbell Back Squat	4 x 6-8	3 min
Romanian Deadlift	3 x 8-10	2 min
Leg Press	3 x 10-12	90 sec
Walking Lunges	2 x 12/leg	90 sec
Leg Curl	3 x 12	60 sec
Standing Calf Raise	4 x 15	45 sec

PUSH DAY B (Fri)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Overhead Barbell Press	4 x 6-8	2-3 min
Flat Dumbbell Press	3 x 8-10	90 sec
Cable Fly	3 x 12-15	60 sec
Dumbbell Lateral Raise	3 x 15	60 sec
Close-Grip Bench Press	3 x 8-10	90 sec
Diamond Push-ups (or cable)	2 x AMRAP	60 sec

PULL DAY B (Sat)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Barbell Row	4 x 6-8	2 min
Chin-ups (underhand)	3 x 8-10	90 sec
Single-Arm Dumbbell Row	3 x 10/side	90 sec
Rear Delt Fly	3 x 15	60 sec
Incline Dumbbell Curl	3 x 10-12	60 sec
Preacher Curl	2 x 12	60 sec

LEG DAY B (Sun, if training 6 days — else rotate in)

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Rest
Front Squat or Hack Squat	4 x 8	2-3 min
Bulgarian Split Squat	3 x 10/leg	90 sec
Leg Extension	3 x 12-15	60 sec
Seated Leg Curl	3 x 12-15	60 sec
Seated Calf Raise	4 x 15	45 sec
Hanging Leg Raise (core)	3 x 12-15	60 sec

Cardio

Not a priority for a lean bulk, but 2x/week of 15–20 min incline walking or light cycling post-workout supports heart health and appetite without eating into recovery.

6. Periodization: August → December

Phase	Weeks	Focus
Phase 1 — Foundation	Aug (Wk 1–4)	Re-groove movement patterns, moderate weights, nail form, small surplus. Expect fast "muscle memory" strength returns.
Phase 2 — Hypertrophy Push	Sep–Oct (Wk 5–12)	Push volume and loads progressively. This is where most size comes from. Increase calories slightly if weight gain stalls.
Phase 3 — Intensification	Nov (Wk 13–16)	Slightly heavier/lower reps on main lifts (5–6 range) to convert size to strength, keep accessories in hypertrophy range.
Phase 4 — Consolidate & Deload	Dec (Wk 17–20)	One deload week (50% volume) mid-month to let joints/CNS recover, then reassess for next block into 2026.

Checkpoints

- **End of August:** Bodyweight ~60–61 kg, strength should already feel noticeably better on main lifts.
 - **End of September:** ~62 kg, visible muscle fullness returning.
 - **End of October:** ~63–64 kg (back to old peak weight, but likely leaner + stronger than before since you're eating in a controlled surplus vs however you ate last time).
 - **End of November:** ~64–65 kg.
 - **End of December:** ~65–66 kg, realistic honest target. If you're leaner than expected, push toward 67–68 in the new year with continued surplus.
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7. Tracking & Recovery Non-Negotiables

- **Sleep 7–8 hours** — this is when muscle protein synthesis and growth hormone release peak. Undersleeping undermines everything above.
- **Weigh in daily, log weekly average.**
- **Progress photos** — front/side/back, every 2 weeks, same lighting.
- **Waist measurement** — every 2 weeks, at navel. This is your fat-gain early warning system independent of scale weight.

- **Log your lifts** — use a notes app or a lifting app (Strong, Hevy). If you don't track numbers, you can't confirm progressive overload is happening.
 - **Deload every 6-8 weeks** if you feel beat up, don't wait for the scheduled Phase 4 deload if your joints/sleep/motivation are tanking.
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Quick Reference Summary

- **Calories:** ~2,800/day, adjust every 2 weeks based on weekly-average weight trend
- **Protein:** 150g/day minimum, spread across 4-5 meals
- **Creatine:** 5g/day, every day, no loading phase needed
- **Training:** 5x/week PPL, progressive overload on every main lift
- **Sleep:** 7-8 hrs
- **Reassess:** every 4 weeks — recalculate calories/protein as bodyweight changes